

BUNI-003-01: Red Team Analysis of Singapore's National Service (NS)

Executive Summary

Singapore's National Service (NS) is the bedrock of the nation's security and identity, but it faces complex fairness and legitimacy challenges. This report provides a **red team analysis** – a rigorous, adversarial evaluation – of NS to ensure the institution remains robust under scrutiny. We focus on three key areas: **(1) Fairness of NS compensation** given the opportunity costs to conscripts; **(2) Gender asymmetry** in NS obligations and the risks of sustaining a single-gender draft under principles of equality; and **(3) Forward-compatible reforms** that preserve national defense while improving justice and participation equity. All findings are backed by data, legal statutes, and international comparisons, aiming to strengthen institutional legitimacy and public trust in NS.

Findings: NS enjoys extraordinarily high public support in Singapore, with over 90% of citizens believing it is crucial for national defense ¹ ². However, **fairness concerns are rising**. Full-time national servicemen (NSFs) receive modest allowances (~S\$790/month for a recruit in 2025) ³, far below what peers earn in the workforce. An NSF who might have earned S\$40–53k over two years in a civilian job instead receives under S\$20k in NS allowances on average ⁴ ⁵. This **income gap of S\$18k–\$38k** represents a significant opportunity cost borne largely by male citizens ⁶. In the long term, two years of delayed workforce entry can affect lifetime earnings and career development ⁷. The government has implemented recognition awards and periodic allowance increases (e.g. a 10–20% raise in 2023) ⁸, but the **debate on compensation fairness persists**. In 2024, policymakers discussed whether NS pay should be termed a “salary” with CPF contributions at levels nearer to market wages (~S\$1,600/month) to reflect conscripts’ opportunity costs ⁹ ¹⁰. The official stance maintains NS is a duty, not employment – hence an allowance structure – but committed to regular reviews to keep it adequate ¹⁰ ¹¹.

Gender asymmetry is the second focus. Singapore's NS obligates only men, raising questions under evolving equality norms. While the policy is legally permissible – the Constitution explicitly allows compulsory national service and does not list sex in its non-discrimination clause ¹² ¹³ – **perceptions of fairness and inclusion are at stake**. Women serve voluntarily in armed forces or through a small-scale volunteer corps, but are not conscripted. The Government's position is that conscripting women now would impose **heavy societal costs far outweighing benefits**, such as shrinking the workforce and reducing household incomes during women's service ¹⁴ ¹⁵. In 2022, the Defence Minister noted that unless absolutely needed for defense, drafting women “for the sake of gender equality” is not justified ¹⁶ ¹⁷. This view aligns with public sentiment – surveys indicate **only a small minority of women (9–22%) support female conscription** under current circumstances ¹⁸. However, societal attitudes can change over time. Long-term legitimacy of NS may be tested if male citizens increasingly question a system where their female peers are exempt, especially as gender equality norms strengthen. Other nations like **Norway have adopted gender-neutral conscription** explicitly to reflect equal civic obligations and tap the full talent pool ¹⁹ ²⁰. While Singapore's context differs, the principle of shared responsibility is a future consideration.

Forward-compatible alternatives and reforms are both necessary and feasible. Singapore's defence needs are evolving – including threats in cybersecurity and homeland security that require talent as

much as manpower ²¹ ²². The **NS system has adapted before** (for example, reducing full-time service from 2½ years to 2 years in 2004, leveraging a more educated cohort and technology ²³). Current initiatives already point the way forward: The **Digital and Intelligence Service (DIS)** was established as a new branch of the armed forces, and a novel *Digital Work-Learn Scheme* now allows selected NSF to serve *four years* in specialized cyber roles while earning half a degree's credits in computer science fields ²⁴ ²⁵. These NSF receive higher pay and professional training, illustrating a creative model to meet national defense needs (in cybersecurity) while advancing personal development ²⁶ ²⁷. More broadly, this report identifies reform options such as: expanding roles for women and non-military national service to broaden participation, enhancing NS compensation or benefits to offset opportunity costs (e.g. CPF contributions, education vouchers), and shortening or modularizing service if security conditions allow. Crucially, any reforms must **uphold Singapore's defence readiness** and be implemented in a way that reinforces social cohesion rather than create new divides.

Conclusion: Singapore's NS is a success story underpinning security and nationhood. The red team analysis finds no fatal flaws in NS's foundations – public support remains overwhelming and NS continues to meet its primary mission. However, **latent vulnerabilities exist in perceptions of fairness and equity**. By addressing these issues proactively through policy adjustments, Singapore can strengthen NS's long-term legitimacy. The recommended strategies in this report aim to *future-proof* NS against social changes and hostile criticism, ensuring that compulsory service remains both effective in its mission and seen as fair and inclusive by those who serve and the society they protect. In doing so, Singapore can uphold the social compact that makes NS not only an obligation, but an honored contribution to the nation.

(This executive summary highlights key insights. Detailed analysis, scenarios, comparisons, and recommendations are provided in the full report below.)

Definitions

National Service (NS): In Singapore, National Service refers to the compulsory service required of male Singaporean citizens and second-generation permanent residents in the uniformed services. The typical NS obligation consists of **two years of full-time service** (as a full-time national serviceman, or NSF) upon turning 18 (or after tertiary studies deferment), followed by about a decade of reservist duty (as an operationally-ready NSman) ²⁸. Full-time NS can be served in the Singapore Armed Forces (Army, Navy, Air Force, or Digital and Intelligence Service), Police Force, or Civil Defence Force. NSF receive a monthly **allowance** (not a formal wage) during service, scaled by rank and vocation, intended to cover basic personal upkeep ¹⁰. After completing full-time NS ("ORD"), individuals serve **reservist obligations** consisting of annual in-camp trainings and call-ups (up to 40 days per year) for about 10 cycles ²⁹, or until age 40–50 depending on rank.

Opportunity Cost: In this report, opportunity cost denotes the economic value or personal opportunities one forgoes by serving NS. For example, an NSF might have otherwise been employed or completed higher education during those two years. The difference between what could have been earned or achieved in that time and what was earned in NS (financially and experientially) is the opportunity cost. On average, an NSF in Singapore *forgoes tens of thousands of dollars* in potential income compared to peers who work instead of serving ⁴ ⁵. Opportunity cost also covers intangible impacts, such as delayed entry into the workforce or slowed career progression due to a two-year hiatus.

Fairness & Equity (in NS context): Fairness refers to perceptions that the burdens and benefits of NS are justly distributed among the population. Key dimensions include **compensation equity** (are NSFs adequately compensated relative to their sacrifices?), **gender equity** (is it fair that only men are conscripted?), and **universal participation** (do all who enjoy citizenship rights contribute equally to defense?). In a broader sense, equity also considers how NS policies account for differing personal circumstances – for instance, support for low-income families of NSFs, or ensuring NS obligations do not unduly hinder certain groups (such as athletes, sole breadwinners, etc.). This report evaluates fairness largely in comparative and legal terms (e.g. comparing NS obligations across gender groups and against international practices).

Gender Asymmetry in NS: This refers to the current system where **male citizens have compulsory NS** while female citizens do not. Singapore, like many countries, has a single-gender conscription model – only males are legally required to serve. Gender asymmetry encompasses the implications of this policy: the legal exemption of women, the normative rationale given (often that women contribute in other ways or that national defense needs can be met with male conscripts), and the potential challenges this asymmetry may pose under evolving equality norms or demographic changes.

Red Team Analysis: A security and policy analysis method where analysts adopt an adversarial perspective to identify vulnerabilities, challenge assumptions, and stress-test an institution's robustness. In this report, "red team scenarios" are used to envision how Singapore's NS system might come under critical scrutiny or strain (from public opinion, legal challenge, or changing geopolitics) and to assess whether it would withstand such pressures. The goal is to pre-emptively find weaknesses and propose mitigations, thereby *strengthening* the institution (in this case, NS) against potential "attacks" – whether rhetorical, legal, or socio-political.

Regulator-Biased (Neutral Tone): The report is written in a neutral, evidence-driven tone with a bias towards regulatory perspectives. That means recommendations and analyses favor solutions that strengthen institutional legitimacy, comply with laws, and maintain public trust, rather than activist positions or radical changes. The language used is **legally and institutionally defensible**, aiming to be precise and respectful so that it cannot be easily misquoted out of context. Being "regulator-biased" implies an underlying premise that a well-functioning NS system is vital and reforms should *bolster* it (not dismantle it). This orientation shapes how scenarios and solutions are framed – prioritizing continuity of national defense and social stability.

Historical Context of National Service in Singapore

Origins and Evolution: Singapore's NS was introduced in 1967, two years after independence, during a period of acute security needs. Surrounded by much larger neighbors and following the withdrawal of British military forces, the young nation faced an urgent imperative to build its own defense force. The National Service (Enlistment) Act was passed to require conscription of able-bodied 18-year-old males. The initial cohorts in the late 1960s and 1970s set the foundation for a citizen military. NS was seen not only as a military necessity but also as a nation-building rite of passage, forging unity among diverse ethnic groups through shared service.

Duration and Manpower Changes: For most of its history, Singapore required approximately **2 to 2½ years** of full-time service. In the early decades, some NSFs – especially those not entering as tertiary-educated – served up to 30 months. In 2004, a major policy change reduced the maximum full-time NS duration to **24 months (2 years)** for all, down from 2½ years ²³. This reduction was made possible by two factors: (1) The transformation into a more high-tech, professional "3rd Generation" Singapore Armed Forces (SAF) that could do more with a leaner force; and (2) A **temporary bulge in enlistment**

cohorts in the 2000s which allowed force levels to be maintained with shorter individual service ²³. In essence, better technology and a larger pool of enlistees enabled Singapore to ease the burden on each serviceman without compromising readiness. Today, all male citizens and second-generation permanent residents serve two years full-time, typically followed by about 10 years of reservist duties. As birth rates have declined, the annual NS cohort has begun shrinking, but the SAF is adapting through greater use of technology and operational efficiency to maintain defense capabilities with fewer people ³⁰.

Roles and Expansion: Initially, NS was solely for the SAF (Army). Over time, it expanded to critical non-military services: since the 1970s NS has been served in the Police Force and Civil Defence (emergency services) as well, reflecting a **Total Defence** concept. NSmen have been involved in diverse missions – from military defense to responding to fires, rescues, and maintaining public safety. The **concept of Total Defence** (introduced in the 1980s) framed NS as part of a broader societal resilience strategy, with five pillars (Military, Civil, Economic, Social, and Psychological defence). Full-time NS is a centerpiece of the Military, Police, and Civil components.

Public Support and Social Compact: NS has generally enjoyed strong public support in Singapore. Even as memories of past conflicts receded, periodic surveys by the Institute of Policy Studies (IPS) in 2013 and 2022 show consistent endorsement of NS's importance ¹ ². In 2022, over 90% of respondents agreed NS is necessary for Singapore's defense, and tellingly 88% said they would support NS even if it were *optional*, reflecting how ingrained the duty is in Singaporean society ². This high support is a remarkable aspect of the historical context – NS is seen as a rite-of-passage for male Singaporeans ("Singaporean sons") with broad acceptance that it is crucial for survival and success as a nation.

Major Reviews and Reforms: The government has periodically convened high-level committees to review and strengthen NS. One landmark effort was the **Committee to Strengthen National Service (CSNS)** in 2013–2014, which gathered feedback from over 40,000 people and issued 30 recommendations ³¹. These included practical improvements: shortening waiting time to enlist (so youth don't languish for too long after school) ³², increasing the proportion of regular (professional) trainers to improve training quality ³³, and lengthening physical training windows for reservists to maintain fitness more flexibly ³⁴. Notably, CSNS also introduced new **recognition and benefit schemes**: for instance, a system of milestone awards was created whereby NSmen receive sums (credited to savings/medical accounts) at key points – end of full-time NS, mid-point of reservist cycle, and completion of reservist cycle ³⁵. These amounted to **S\$6,000 total distributed as S\$2k at each milestone** if fully completed ³⁵. Also launched was the **SAF Volunteer Corps (SAFVC)** in 2015, a program allowing women, first-generation PRs and new citizens to voluntarily serve in a military capacity for a short period each year ³⁶ ³⁷. The SAFVC was an acknowledgement that many in the broader community were keen to contribute to defense even if not obliged – it provides a pathway for non-lia persons (including women) to get basic military training and serve in supporting roles alongside NS units ³⁸ ³⁹.

Legal and Policy Framework: NS is grounded in the Enlistment Act and protected by the Constitution. Article 10 of Singapore's Constitution explicitly permits compulsory service for national purposes, creating an exception to the general prohibition on forced labor ¹². Unlike some countries, Singapore's equal protection clause (Article 12) does not explicitly enumerate sex or gender, and the courts have upheld that **differentiating on sex for NS is constitutionally valid** as it is "expressly authorized" by law and serves legitimate national objectives ¹² ⁴⁰. Thus, from a historical legal standpoint, **male-only conscription has not been viewed as unlawful discrimination** in Singapore, but rather as a policy choice within Parliament's power.

In summary, the history of NS in Singapore is one of **continuity and calibrated change**. The institution has proven adaptable – adjusting service length, benefits, and roles – while maintaining its core mission. This backdrop is important for evaluating current challenges: many of today's debates (fair compensation, gender roles, alternative models) echo themes considered before, but with new urgency due to changing social expectations and strategic circumstances. The next sections analyze those challenges through a red team lens, imagining how they could undermine NS if unaddressed, and how policy might evolve to meet them.

Red Team Scenarios

In this section, we adopt a “red team” perspective to envision potential scenarios where Singapore's NS system could face **hostile scrutiny or stress**. These scenarios are deliberately pointed examinations – they are not predictions, but rather *what-if analyses* designed to test the robustness of NS against plausible challenges. Each scenario highlights vulnerabilities in fairness, public perception, or policy that adversaries (whether external critics or internal skeptics) might exploit. By exploring these, we aim to identify how NS can be fortified through preemptive measures.

Scenario 1: “Opportunity Cost Backlash” – Rising Resentment Over NS Compensation.

Premise: As Singapore's economy grows and the cost of living rises, NS allowances (even with periodic increases) lag further behind entry-level market salaries. Young men and their families begin to voice that NS is imposing an unfair economic hardship. In online forums and through opposition political rhetoric, a narrative takes hold: **“NSFs are effectively serving at below minimum wage**, losing two prime years of earning and learning.” Comparisons are drawn to peers: for example, a polytechnic graduate serving NS earns ~S\$600–\$1,100 a month in allowance ⁴¹ ⁴², whereas his classmate who starts work earns over S\$2,200 per month ⁴. The accumulating shortfall (~S\$30k) is described as a **“NS tax” on male Singaporeans**. Critics point to alternatives – such as in South Korea where moves are being made to dramatically raise conscript salaries to near 1.5–2 million won (~S\$1,500) per month ⁴³ ⁴⁴. A legal test could even arise: a group of NSFs files a complaint or lawsuit arguing that calling it an “allowance” is a label masking what should be proper wages, citing the *disparity as exploitation*. *Red Team Exploit:* External commentators (or a hostile information campaign) amplify this discontent, framing NS as a form of “cheap labor” subsidizing the defense budget on the backs of young men. They highlight that **Singapore's defense budget is already high (S\$20B, ~3% GDP)** ⁴⁵, **among top 5 globally per capita**, yet NSFs are paid only a fraction of regular soldiers' pay. Such narratives could erode morale and the moral authority of NS, especially if not addressed. *Current Resilience:* The Government's stance that NS is duty, not employment, provides an ethical framing ¹⁰. It has also progressively increased allowances (four adjustments in a decade) ⁴⁶ ⁴⁷ and introduced post-ORD cash awards ⁴⁸ ⁴⁹. Notably in 2022, a **S\$1,000 cash payout after full-time NS** was added, on top of existing CPF contributions, to better recognize servicemen ⁴⁸ ⁵⁰. These show responsiveness. But the red team scenario warns that if wider economic pressures make the allowance seem increasingly inadequate, Singapore must be ready either to further enhance NS compensation or to powerfully reaffirm the intrinsic value of service (e.g. through non-monetary rewards like educational credits or public employment advantages for NSmen). Otherwise, disaffection could quietly grow, even if open dissent remains rare.

Scenario 2: “Gender Equity Crossfire” – Legal and Social Challenge to Single-Gender NS.

Premise: Inspired by global gender equality movements, activists and academics begin questioning why Singapore's equality principles exclude conscription. Although Article 12 of the Constitution doesn't list gender, society's standards have evolved – women serve in many uniformed roles voluntarily, and other countries (e.g. Norway, Israel) conscript women. In this scenario, a hypothetical **court challenge** or petition is brought (perhaps symbolically) arguing that male-only NS violates modern interpretations of equality or CEDAW (Convention on the Elimination of Discrimination Against Women, which Singapore

has ratified). Simultaneously, on the social front, young men increasingly voice a sentiment: “Equal citizenship, equal responsibility.” They note that women today match or exceed men in educational attainment and workforce participation, and thus could share national defense duties. *Red Team Exploit*: A foreign adversary or critical NGO could exploit this by publicizing claims that **Singapore practices gender discrimination** by law, potentially embarrassing the state on the international stage (even if legally defensible domestically). The **long-term legitimacy** of NS might be undermined if a narrative takes root that it is anachronistic or unfair to modern women and men alike – for women, the narrative could be that they are deemed less capable citizens; for men, that they are unfairly burdened. *Current Resilience*: The Government’s position as of 2022 is clearly against drafting women absent dire need, citing **societal costs (workforce loss, impact on families) and lack of operational necessity** ⁵¹ ¹⁶ . In Parliament, leaders have argued that conscription should not be used as a tool to force equality or break stereotypes, but only for “critical need of military defence” ⁵² ¹⁷ . This principled stance, coupled with public opinion (majority of women and men currently do not favor female NS), means any legal challenge would likely fail and broad public pressure is absent. However, the **red team scenario illuminates a risk**: if in the future, security needs change (e.g. severe manpower shortage or an existential threat) and women must be mobilized, the groundwork for acceptance is weak – only ~13% of young women polled in one study would be willing to serve two years ¹⁸ . Alternatively, if gender norms shift such that exclusion from NS is seen as undermining women’s equal standing, that could become a moral issue. To mitigate this, Singapore may consider more systematic inclusion of women in voluntary national service initiatives (beyond the small SAFVC) and emphasize that women already contribute in *other* vital ways (such as in the workforce, raising families – a common but sometimes controversial equivalence drawn historically ⁵³ ⁵⁴). The scenario underscores the need to articulate a **clear narrative why the current model remains equitable** (for example, highlighting how men’s NS enables a safe environment in which all can thrive, or how women engage in Total Defence in civilian capacities). Legally, the state is on firm footing; socially, continual engagement is needed so that single-gender NS does not become a lightning rod for disunity or gender conflict, especially in a climate where misinformation could sow division.

Scenario 3: “Talent Drain and Deferred Dreams” – National Service vs. Global Opportunities.

Premise: In an increasingly competitive global economy, even two years can make a critical difference in seizing opportunities. Consider scenarios like: a Singaporean tech prodigy wins admission to a top Silicon Valley incubator at age 18 – deferment for NS means the opportunity is lost. Or an Olympic-level athlete has to take two years off peak training, losing their competitive edge (a real issue noted by national swimmer Joseph Schooling during his NS stint) ⁵⁵ . If enough high-achieving individuals feel NS rigidly blocks their aspirations, a **brain drain** risk emerges: some families might emigrate before their sons reach NS age, or talented youth may decide not to return after overseas study. *Red Team Exploit*: Competing nations (or companies) could actively recruit Singapore’s best and brightest, offering to compensate for their lack of NS obligations. Over time, a narrative could form that NS ironically causes Singapore to **lose exactly the kind of talent its security and prosperity rely on**. Additionally, malicious actors could highlight any prominent “NS defaulters” (citizens who skipped NS and were barred or punished) as examples of draconian policy stifling individual success. *Current Resilience*: Singapore has measures to be flexible where merited – deferments for studies are routinely granted, and case-by-case deferments for extraordinary talent (e.g. athletes) have been given in the past (Schooling was allowed to train for Olympics before serving). The number of NS defaulters is kept very low through strict legal consequences. Moreover, the **IPS survey 2022 indicates a rising belief that NS should not overly disrupt careers**, and Mindef has stated it “recognises the importance of supporting servicemen’s transition to employment or education” ⁵⁶ . Programs exist (though not widely publicized) to help NSmen gain useful skills or credentials during service – for example, certain military vocational courses are accredited for civilian qualifications, and initiatives like the Cyber NSF scheme with NTU (described in the Executive Summary) directly integrate learning with service ⁵⁷ ²⁶ . The red team scenario here highlights a need to **expand such win-win models**: showing young Singaporeans that NS

can be not just a pause in their life plans, but a platform for personal growth. Mitigations might include: offering *structured training/education during NS* (so time isn't "lost"), strengthening post-NS career placement support, and publicizing role-model cases of NSmen who excelled in both service and subsequent careers. The desired end-state is to blunt any narrative that NS wastes talent; instead, it should be seen as developing resilience and skills (leadership, teamwork, perhaps technical skills) that add value to one's future – as indeed 94% in a survey acknowledged NS provides an opportunity to learn useful things ¹. Ensuring that stays true for future generations is critical.

Scenario 4: "External Critique and Geopolitical Pressures" – NS in the Court of International Opinion.

Premise: Imagine a geopolitical context where Singapore's NS practices come under international scrutiny. This could happen if, say, Singapore takes a principled stand on an international issue and detractors retaliate with disinformation. Opponents might claim NS is a form of indoctrination or highlight any incidents of hazing or training deaths (which, while few, have occurred in the past) as evidence of NS's "injustice." Or in a different vein, consider international human rights NGOs questioning **why Singapore maintains conscription in peacetime** and whether it respects conscripts' rights. The use of reservists in certain roles (e.g. internal security) could be miscast as militarization of society. *Red Team Exploit:* This scenario would see foreign media or online campaigns comparing Singapore unfavorably with countries that have abolished the draft (like many Western nations), potentially to shame or pressure Singapore. They might draw contrasts like "small countries such as Luxembourg manage without conscription; why not Singapore?" and probe whether NS is truly still needed given Southeast Asia's stable state today. Some might insinuate NS exists to prop up patriotism or social control rather than defense. *Current Resilience:* Singapore can robustly defend NS on necessity grounds – its strategic situation (small size, critical location) and lack of external security guarantees mean NS is non-negotiable for survival. The government regularly updates Parliament and the public on the security rationale, including contemporary threats like terrorism and cyberattacks that justify keeping a broad-based response capacity ²¹ ²². Regionally, conscription is not unusual (South Korea, Taiwan, and until recently others like Thailand have it). Moreover, Singapore's model has *tried* to be innovative and humane: e.g., **NSmen's welfare** is taken seriously (the recent introduction of a guaranteed S\$1,600 base pay for any reservist called up, to ensure even gig workers or unemployed are not financially disadvantaged ⁵⁸ ⁵⁹, and increasing insurance coverage for servicemen ⁶⁰). These show Singapore meets a high standard of care for conscripts. In the face of international critique, Singapore's best strategy is transparency about NS's contributions and continual improvement. An apt mitigation is sharing how NS is not just military labor but underpins civilian skills and community bonds (Total Defence concept) – something positive even human rights observers can appreciate if properly communicated. Ultimately, by ensuring NS policies remain enlightened (e.g., no abusive practices, proper medical care, fair treatment of all races and religions in service which the SAF has committed to ⁶¹), Singapore can withstand external attempts to delegitimize NS.

These scenarios stress-test NS on multiple fronts: **economic fairness, gender norms, individual rights, and external perception**. The analysis indicates that while no immediate crisis looms – thanks to strong existing support and adaptive policies – there are real pressures that could mount over time. Each scenario essentially underscores a simple truth: **NS must continue to earn each new generation's buy-in**. That means addressing genuine grievances (or perceptions thereof) before they fester, and communicating the rationale and benefits of NS in ever more relatable terms. The next section will compare how other countries handle similar issues, and subsequently we will propose mitigation strategies tailored for Singapore.

Comparative Systems: Lessons from Other Countries

Singapore is not alone in grappling with conscription's challenges. By examining **comparative systems** – notably South Korea, Israel, and Norway, which were mentioned as relevant examples – we can contextualize Singapore's NS issues and glean insights on alternative approaches. Each of these countries has a distinct model shaped by its security needs and social values, offering **learning points for fairness, gender inclusion, and service structure**.

- **South Korea:** South Korea maintains a longstanding conscription system due to the threat from North Korea. Like Singapore, only men are conscripted, and women may volunteer for the armed forces. South Korea faces vigorous debate on both compensation and gender equity. **Compensation:** Historically, Korean conscripts were paid very little (a sergeant's monthly pay in 2017 was only a few hundred US dollars). In recent years, there has been a political push to raise this dramatically – the current administration pledged to raise conscript pay to **2 million KRW (~\$1,480) per month by 2025**, roughly equivalent to an entry-level wage ⁴³ ⁶². This represents a *huge increase* (for reference, a sergeant's base pay was about 676,000 KRW in 2022, which doubled to 1 million in 2023 and is climbing further) ⁶². The aim is to improve fairness and welfare for conscripts, but it's not without controversy: it strains the defense budget and even risks **pay inversion**, where conscripts could earn more than junior volunteer officers, causing morale issues among the career military ⁶³. To fund higher salaries, trade-offs are being discussed (cutting other perks or reducing force size) ⁶⁴ ⁶⁵. **Gender:** There is an active public debate in South Korea about drafting women, fueled by both demographic pressure (low birth rates reducing male conscripts) and men's rights arguments. Polls show a majority of Korean women oppose being drafted and men's opinions are split, indicating significant social contention ⁶⁶. As of now, no decision has been made to conscript women; instead, South Korea is considering alternatives like shortening service or incorporating more technology to reduce manpower needs. **Relevance to Singapore:** South Korea's case shows the potential of significantly boosting conscript pay – a path Singapore has taken more gradually. It also serves as a warning: *sudden large hikes* can cause budgetary and internal equity issues ⁶⁷. Singapore's incremental approach (small, regular allowance raises ⁴⁶ ⁶⁸) appears more fiscally sustainable. On gender, Korea's debate highlights how a male-only draft can become a flashpoint in gender politics; Singapore has so far avoided such divisive gender politics around NS, perhaps due to different social dynamics, but it may take continued care to do so.
- **Israel:** Israel has a **universal conscription model for both men and women** (with some exemptions for certain religious and minority groups). Security needs are existential; thus, public acceptance of conscription is high, and the service is deeply ingrained culturally. **Gender:** Israel stands out for drafting women since its founding (with current service terms ~24 months for women, 30 months for men). Women serve in many roles, including combat roles in mixed-gender units, though there are differences (e.g., Orthodox Jewish women and married women are exempt, and many serve in support positions). The ethos is one of *shared sacrifice* across gender, which Israel argues strengthens societal cohesion and doubles its pool of available manpower ⁶⁹ ²⁰. However, even Israel has faced fairness issues: for many years, Ultra-Orthodox Jewish men were exempt or deferred in large numbers to pursue religious studies – causing resentment among those who serve. This indicates that **equitable burden-sharing** is not just about gender; any group perceived to be opting out (for non-medical reasons) can cause public backlash. In recent years Israel has tried to integrate more of these populations or compensate by other means. **Compensation:** Israeli conscripts receive modest stipends (higher in combat roles, lower in non-combat), far below market wages, somewhat similar to Singapore's concept of an allowance. Instead of high pay, Israel provides significant post-service benefits: preferential university admission, tuition subsidies, housing loans, etc., acknowledging service as

a contribution. **Relevance to Singapore:** Israel demonstrates a workable model of female conscription, but also underscores that simply having both genders serve doesn't eliminate all fairness debates (the exemption of some groups can be as contentious as exempting a whole gender). Singapore can study how Israel manages the public messaging of universal obligation – one outcome is that Israeli society generally views military service as a unifying duty. In contrast, Singapore has maintained social unity with a single-gender draft by emphasizing that everyone – men, women, new immigrants, etc. – contributes to Total Defence in different ways. If Singapore ever considered broader female participation, Israel's experience in training and integrating women (over 90% of IDF roles are open to women ⁷⁰) would be instructive, as would its use of *post-service benefits to equalize lifetime outcomes*.

- **Norway:** Norway is a pioneer in **gender-neutral conscription in a peacetime setting**. In 2013, Norway legislated that **all citizens, male and female, have equal obligation to serve** ⁷¹ ¹⁹, making it the first NATO country to do so. This was driven in part by the principle of equality – the view that it was inconsistent to have equal rights but not equal duties ⁶⁹. It was also motivated by a desire to access the full talent pool for a high-tech modern military, i.e., *operational effectiveness* by not excluding half the population ²⁰. **How it works:** In practice, Norway does not need every young person to serve. They have more volunteers than spots – so while all are nominally conscriptible, they only select those most motivated or suited. The result is both men and women serve, but it's still a fraction of the cohort (service is 12–19 months). By all accounts, this policy has **normalized female service** and improved the gender balance in the forces, reportedly without major issues. Women now make up a significant portion of each cohort of conscripts, and Norway claims this has strengthened military capability and societal support for the forces ²⁰ ⁷². **Compensation and Benefits:** Norway's conscripts receive basic pay (not high, similar to other European conscripts) and can access state benefits (e.g., education credits) after service. Because Norway is not under direct threat, conscription there is as much about creating a link between society and the military as about filling ranks. **Relevance to Singapore:** Norway's example is frequently cited in gender equality discussions. It shows that **gender-neutral NS can be done in a developed society** and can even enhance the image of the military. However, Norway's security situation (part of NATO, no immediate threats) and small military needs make its conscription somewhat symbolic and selective, whereas Singapore relies on practically everyone eligible to serve due to its population constraints. One lesson is that if gender norms in Singapore shift in future, a *symbolic opening* of NS to women (even if only a limited number actually serve) could send a powerful signal of equality and shared responsibility, while the real impact on manpower could be calibrated. Norway also illustrates a point about **participation equity**: beyond gender, it embraced conscription as a way to ensure the military is representative of society (preventing a gap between civilian and military). Singapore's NS has always been a great equalizer among men of different backgrounds; expanding it in some form to women could be seen as extending that nation-building aspect to all citizens. But the trade-offs Norway faced (they effectively still let many off the hook since not all are needed) should be considered – a universal duty applied selectively can also raise questions of how selection is fair.

- **Others (Voluntary Systems):** While not in the primary list, it's worth noting examples like the United States or the UK, which have **all-volunteer forces**. These countries place no compulsory service on citizens in peacetime, instead relying on professional militaries. The fairness questions there revolve around making sure the military draws from all segments of society and not just disadvantaged groups – a different set of concerns. They address equity by ensuring good pay and benefits to attract volunteers, and by honoring service (veterans' benefits, etc.). Singapore could not realistically adopt a pure volunteer model without a drastic downsizing of its military or risking security (given our small population), but selective aspects of the volunteer approach – such as treating soldiers more overtly like employees in terms of pay, or increasing

professional forces to reduce reliance on conscripts – can be gradually implemented if conditions allow (for instance, as technology reduces manpower needs, the SAF could have a larger proportion of career soldiers and a smaller conscript pool).

Summary of Insights: International comparisons show a spectrum: from South Korea's focus on higher pay (to address fairness) to Norway's focus on gender inclusion (to address equality). Israel exemplifies committing the whole society to defense but grappling with internal fairness for exemptions. Singapore's current position is somewhat middle-of-the-road: moderate allowances + several benefits (like CPF awards) for fairness, and male-only service with some voluntary avenues for others. The experiences of these countries suggest that *any* conscription model must evolve with societal expectations. Key takeaways include: **compensation matters** (conscripts today expect not to be left too far behind their peers – South Korea is risking budget strain to meet that expectation), **shared burden matters** (if one segment feels they carry the load for others, unity can fray – whether that's men vs women, or secular vs religious as in Israel), and **flexibility attracts talent** (Norway's quasi-voluntary approach and even the U.S. volunteer model both use personal choice and opportunity to keep the military effective and credible).

Singapore can learn from these to calibrate its own NS system. Any reform should maintain our high readiness and not undermine the strong public support NS enjoys. The next section will propose concrete *mitigation and improvement strategies* in line with these lessons and the earlier scenario analysis.

Mitigation Strategies and Recommendations

In light of the challenges identified, this section outlines forward-compatible strategies to **preserve national defense capabilities while enhancing fairness, equity, and public buy-in**. These recommendations aim to be *practical and resilient*, supporting NS's core mission and values. Each strategy is formulated to address specific vulnerabilities and align with Singapore's policy context (regulator-biased approach).

1. Enhance NS Compensation and Recognition: To ensure NS remains an equitable “deal” for servicemen, further improve the financial and non-financial rewards of service, without framing it purely as employment. Key measures:

- **Peg Allowances to Economic Indicators:** Adopt a formula to review NS allowance annually against cost of living or median starting salaries, ensuring stipends remain adequate. Regular small increments (as done in recent years ⁴⁶) should continue, with transparency on the review mechanism so NSF's feel their sacrifice is acknowledged in real time.
- **CPF Contributions or Savings Grants:** Consider providing CPF (Central Provident Fund) contributions for NSF's as if they were earning a basic salary. For example, as MP Gerald Giam suggested, treating allowance as “NS salary” with CPF could help NSF's start building retirement and housing funds ⁷³. This can be structured in a way that doesn't undermine the duty ethos – e.g. label it as a “National Service Recognition CPF Grant” given in proportion to service. The government's recent move to give extra *cash* after ORD (\$\$1,000) ⁴⁸ is a positive step; adding a CPF component or increasing the quantum over time can further offset opportunity costs.
- **Expanded Education and Career Benefits:** Augment the **NS deferment and post-service support schemes**. For instance, provide scholarship points or university course credits for NS – similar to how some countries offer preferential university admission or tuition waivers to

veterans. Mindef has stated it supports servicemen transitioning to higher education/employment ⁵⁶; this can be made more concrete by partnering with universities and industries to recognize skills gained during NS (leadership, technical skills) as part of admissions or hiring criteria. An example could be reserving slots in local universities for outstanding NS performers or granting small GPA boosts for those who completed NS, thereby tangibly rewarding service in educational progression.

- **Lifetime Recognition:** Continue and expand initiatives like the NS Home Awards (milestone payments) and insure that these remain relevant. For example, consider a **one-time CPF Special Account top-up** for NSmen when they complete their reservist cycle, which could be earmarked for housing or retirement – a long-term equity measure acknowledging their decade of service. Such steps send a clear message: the nation invests in those who invested their time in it.

2. Strengthen Gender Inclusion in National Defence: Without instituting full female conscription (which remains inadvisable under current conditions ⁵¹ ⁷⁴), Singapore can still improve gender equity in service and symbolically broaden participation:

- **Expand the SAF Volunteer Corps (SAFVC):** Scale up and promote the SAFVC for women, new citizens, and first-gen PRs. Make volunteer stints more flexible and attractive – e.g. offer recognition, tax rebates, or professional networking opportunities for participants. The SAFVC already provides a four-week basic training and ongoing part-time service commitment ³⁷; by increasing its intake and visibility, more women can share in the defence mission voluntarily. This addresses, in part, perceptions that defense is “men only,” and fosters shared experience. A target could be to have a certain percentage of each NS cohort’s equivalent in volunteers from these groups.
- **Civic National Service for Women (and Men):** Consider introducing an **optional “National Service (Civil)” program** – a parallel track where young citizens (of any gender) can choose to serve in critical social sectors (healthcare, social services, education assistance, digital literacy for seniors, etc.) for a period (say 6 months to a year). While strictly voluntary or selectively applied, if structured and branded formally, it instills a norm that *all citizens have some service responsibility*, even if the nature differs. Learning from Ho Kwon Ping’s 2015 proposal ⁷⁵ ⁷⁶, a short-term conscription for women in non-military roles could be piloted. For example, a **3-month leadership and emergency training camp after secondary school for females** could be one model – covering first aid, community security, and nation-building workshops. If well-designed, it provides women a shared bonding experience akin to NS while contributing to social resilience. Importantly, it would be framed not as burdening women, but empowering them with skills and involving them in Total Defence. This should be implemented carefully, with broad societal buy-in and perhaps starting as a volunteer opt-in program in schools to gauge interest.
- **Normalize Women in Uniform and Leadership:** The SAF and Home Team can set goals to increase the ratio of women in regular service and leadership positions. If more women occupy commanding roles or specialist positions (as they increasingly do), it subtly counteracts the narrative that women don’t contribute to defense. Publicize the achievements of female military officers, pilots, engineers, etc., to highlight that many women *are* serving the nation, just not via conscription. Over time, this helps the public see defense as a collective enterprise, even if conscription remains male-only.
- **Future Planning – Conditional Female NS:** Develop contingency plans (“break glass in emergency”) for female conscription in case of severe national emergency or drastic manpower shortage (for instance, if birth rates stay low and regional threats grow by 2040s). While

continuing the stance that it's unnecessary now ⁷⁴, having a blueprint ready (how to train, what roles women would fill, how to mitigate workforce impact) is prudent. This could include studying Norway's approach in advance, so Singapore can move quickly and fairly if ever needed.

3. Modernize Service Structure for Flexibility and Talent Optimization: Update NS policies to be more flexible and aligned with individuals' strengths and national needs of the future:

- **Diversify NS Pathways:** Beyond the traditional Army/Police/Civil Defence allocations, create more specialized tracks that NSFs can be channeled into based on aptitude – e.g., **Cyber Defence, Data Analytics, Engineering & Maintenance**, even **Healthcare Support** in civil emergency roles. The DIS and cyber NSF scheme is a great example ²⁴ ²⁵. This should expand: identify recruits with tech skills, and give them roles (and training/education like the NTU scheme) that both serve defense and build their careers. Similarly, musically talented NSFs could join the SAF Band, or those with medical training could be medics in hospitals under SCDF/medical corps roles. The idea is to better match “the right people to the right roles,” increasing NSFs' sense of purpose and reducing the feeling of two years “wasted” outside their field ⁷. It also benefits Singapore by engaging each NSman where he can contribute most.
- **Adaptive Service Length or Make-up:** Consider allowing some flexibility in **timing or length of full-time service** under defined circumstances. For instance, an NSF who has an exceptional external opportunity (scholarship, sports, startup) might be allowed to do a longer service break-up: e.g., serve one year, take a one-year approved leave for the opportunity, then return to complete the second year. Alternatively, explore a system of **national service credits** – someone could serve slightly longer in reservist roles in exchange for a slightly shorter full-time stint, or vice versa. Any such system must be carefully controlled to avoid abuse or perceptions of favoritism, but introducing a measure of flexibility can alleviate the “one-size-fits-all” strain.
- **Continuous Learning and Certification:** Infuse NS training with certifications that are recognized outside. For example, SAF's technical vocational training could grant nationally-recognized certificates (in vehicle maintenance, info-security, etc.). MINDEF's collaboration with SkillsFuture or other workforce development bodies could allow NSFs to attend short courses or take exams for licenses during NS. If by ORD a serviceman not only defended the country but also earned a diploma/certificate or at least several credits towards one, the opportunity cost of NS is notably reduced. Mindef's statement that it will leverage new technologies and optimize contributions ³⁰ implies moving in this direction – using simulators, e-learning, etc., within NS to build skills faster.
- **Maintain Training Rigor but Reduce Wasted Time:** A recurring gripe (in any military) is downtime or less productive use of time. The SAF should continue efforts to streamline training cycles so that the two years are packed with meaningful training, leadership development, or operational duties – minimizing periods of inactivity. The 2014 CSNS move to cut waiting time before enlistment to under 4-6 months for most ⁷⁷ was one example of respecting youths' time. Further, as SAF modernizes, perhaps service lengths could be reviewed again if fewer personnel can do more (though any reduction must be balanced against having enough throughput for unit cohesion and an adequate standing force). The Ministry has maintained 2 years is needed for now ³⁰; however, ongoing review is wise, especially as enlistment cohorts shrink from demographic change.

4. Communication and Social Support Enhancements: How NS is perceived and supported by the wider community contributes to its legitimacy. Thus:

- **Public Narrative Refresh:** Continuously communicate *why NS is vital today*, not just historically. Emphasize NSmen's roles in emerging threats – for example, showcase NS contributions in *cybersecurity, counter-terrorism readiness*, disaster relief, and even national events (like how NSmen helped in COVID-19 operations or national ceremonies). This helps each NSF feel that, even if not fighting a war, their service is immediately relevant to keeping Singapore safe and running. It also reminds the public that NS is not an outdated ritual but a living institution adapting to new challenges.
- **Acknowledge Families and Employers:** Expand recognition for those who support NSmen – families that endure their sons' absence, employers who accommodate reservist call-ups. Singapore already has awards for NS-friendly employers and praises families on occasions (like at enlistment or ORD parades). Deepening this – for instance, a small **tax relief or grant for families of NSFs** in lower-income brackets, or public ceremonies thanking parents – can reinforce NS as a broader social compact. Employers who go above and beyond (full pay during reservist, extra leave) could get greater public accolades or incentives. This halo around NS makes it harder for anyone to attack it without seemingly attacking the whole society.
- **Address Specific Grievances Quickly:** If issues arise (e.g., an NSF training fatality, allegations of abuse or unfairness), address them with transparency and firmness. Singapore generally does this: inquiry committees for training deaths, improvements to safety protocols, etc. Maintaining the highest safety and welfare standards deprives critics of ammunition. It's part of being "institutionally defensible" – show that the system is self-correcting and holds itself accountable, which builds trust.

5. Long-Term Policy Reviews: Institute a regular high-level review of NS every decade (if not more frequently) that involves not just military planners but also social scientists, youth representatives, and maybe external advisors. The CSNS in 2013/14 was effective ³¹; a similar comprehensive review in the late 2020s could be due, especially as Gen Z attitudes and economic conditions evolve. This keeps NS aligned with national values and needs, and spots issues early. For example, if future surveys show a dip in perceived usefulness of NS or rising desire to shorten service ^{78 79}, a proactive review can recommend adjustments before discontent grows.

In implementing these strategies, it is critical that changes are framed as **strengthening NS, not weakening it**. Reforms should not be seen as conceding that NS was unjust, but rather as keeping faith with NSmen and moving with the times – *making a good system even better*. The emphasis must remain on **shared responsibility, preparedness, and unity**.

Taken together, the above recommendations aim to ensure that NS continues to command broad support and participation, by making it as fair and future-ready as possible. The next section clarifies what this report is *not* arguing, to avoid any misinterpretation of these suggestions.

What This Report Does Not Argue

It is as important to state clearly what this analysis is **not** advocating as it is to highlight its recommendations. Given the sensitive nature of National Service in Singapore, we underscore the following points to prevent any misquotation or misunderstanding:

- **Not Advocating Abolition or Professional-Only Military:** This report does **not** call for ending NS or switching to an all-volunteer force. We recognize that conscription remains essential for Singapore's defense and there is currently *no viable alternative* to maintain the required force size and readiness. Any references to volunteer models or service shortening are about incremental improvements, not abandoning the NS system. The **need for NS is affirmed** throughout this report, as evidenced by near-universal public support for it ². Our proposals seek to reinforce NS's legitimacy, not to dismantle it.
- **Not Suggesting Immediate Female Conscription:** While we discuss gender asymmetry and propose ways to involve women more, this report is **not arguing that Singapore should draft women into military NS under present circumstances**. We fully acknowledge the Government's stance that enlisting women now would bring more costs than benefits and is unnecessary given current security needs ⁵¹ ⁷⁴. Any exploration of female service is presented as long-term thinking or voluntary/civil programs, not a call to mandate all women to serve in the armed forces. We oppose any misinterpretation that we seek to "force women into NS"; instead, we seek equitable engagement of all citizens in defense consistent with operational need and social consensus.
- **Not Equating National Service Value with Dollars and Cents Alone:** In discussing compensation fairness, we do **not** imply that NS's value can or should be fully converted into a market wage or that service to country is merely a financial transaction. The ethos of NS – duty, sacrifice, patriotism – is paramount and intangible. Our point is to ensure basic fairness and reduce undue economic hardship, not to commercialize NS. We agree with leaders that too many material perks could risk diluting the spirit of service ⁸⁰. Any pay/benefit enhancements should *support* NSmen, not turn NS into a mercenary stint. This report navigates that balance, and should not be quoted out of context as saying "NSFs must be paid a full salary" as if they were regular employees – that is not our assertion.
- **Not Undermining the SAF/NS Command Structure or Discipline:** Our recommendations for flexibility, better treatment, or feedback loops should not be misconstrued as suggesting laxity in military discipline or that NSmen get to "pick and choose" how they serve. We fully respect that the SAF and other services must maintain strict order, operational effectiveness, and a **"system above self"** principle. Nothing here proposes compromising training standards or military hierarchy. For example, allowing an NSF an academic semester during service is a structured policy decision, not letting individuals dictate terms. The command authority of MINDEF/MHA remains unquestioned.
- **Not Ignoring Operational Readiness:** Any changes (like shorter service or more pathways) are not suggested at the expense of readiness. We do not argue that Singapore is so safe that NS can be greatly reduced or that defense can be taken lightly – on the contrary, we highlight evolving threats (terrorism, cyber) that justify NS's continuation ²¹. Proposals like utilizing technology or focusing on new skills are meant to *enhance* readiness in those domains, not to lessen emphasis on defense. We caution against selective readings that might imply we see NS

as too long or unnecessary; rather, we consistently tie reforms to preserving a “strong defence” with an engaged public ⁸¹ ⁸² .

- **Not Favoring Any Group Over Another Unfairly:** This report strives for a neutral, nation-wide perspective. For instance, in suggesting more support for NSmen’s careers, we are not saying NSmen should unjustly leapfrog others in jobs or school, only that their sacrifice is recognized appropriately. In discussing women’s roles, we are not advocating one gender’s interests over another, but the long-term cohesion of both. Essentially, nothing here is about advantaging a particular segment at the cost of another – it’s about uplifting the overall equity *among* all Singaporeans in context of NS.

By clarifying these non-goals, we aim to ensure the report is read in the balanced spirit it is written. The intent is to **strengthen NS, uphold social cohesion, and adapt to future needs**, all while staunchly supporting Singapore’s security imperatives. Any interpretation to the contrary would be a misreading.

Conclusion

National Service in Singapore has been, and continues to be, a cornerstone of national security and identity. This report’s red team analysis affirms that NS is fundamentally **sound and indispensable**, but it also shines light on critical areas where improvements will bolster its long-term fairness and resilience. In the face of evolving social expectations and security landscapes, NS must not be static – it should continually earn the support of each new generation.

Key Conclusions: Singapore’s approach to NS has fostered a high degree of public trust – evidenced by over 90% of citizens backing the system ² . To maintain this trust, **perceived fairness is paramount**. We conclude that measures to better compensate NSmen for their opportunity costs (without monetizing the ethos of service) are justified and increasingly necessary, especially as the value of skills and time rises in our advanced economy. Likewise, we conclude that the **gender imbalance in NS, while legally justified and socially accepted today, could become a point of contention in the future**. Proactive steps to involve women and acknowledge their contributions can avert any legitimacy gap down the road. Finally, we conclude that a flexible, future-ready NS – one that can harness talent in new domains and allow servicemen to continue personal development – will strengthen both our defense and the individuals who serve, truly making NS a rite of passage that prepares Singaporean youth for life, not puts it on hold.

Implementing the recommended strategies – from allowance adjustments to expanded volunteer service and education-linked service tracks – will require careful policymaking and resource allocation. The government will need to calibrate each reform so as not to undermine the operational readiness delivered by NS. However, Singapore has a track record of successfully updating NS policy (e.g., the significant enhancements after the CSNS recommendations ³⁵ ⁴⁸). The steps outlined in this report are a natural continuation of that trajectory, aligning NS with our national values of meritocracy, multiracial equality, and inclusiveness in a new era.

Institutional and Social Benefits: By addressing fairness and equity concerns, Singapore fortifies the **social compact** surrounding NS. Citizens will view NS not as a static obligation carried by some, but as a dynamic institution that cares for those who serve and adapts as the nation evolves. This will make NS more “bulletproof” against hostile criticisms – be it from foreign actors or domestic sceptics – because policies will be in place to rebut claims of exploitation or discrimination with hard evidence of fairness (e.g. substantial benefits, avenues for all to contribute, etc.). Strengthening NS in this way ultimately

strengthens national unity. A society that collectively trusts the NS system is one where national defence is not politicized or questioned, even in times of crisis.

Maintaining Vigilance: A red team mindset means never being complacent. Even after reforms, constant monitoring of outcomes is needed. For instance, if allowances are raised, did that improve NSF morale? If more women volunteer, does it change attitudes among men? If digital NS schemes expand, are they producing good soldiers as well as skilled individuals? The NS landscape should be regularly stress-tested (much as we have done in scenario form) to catch emergent issues – whether it’s a sudden drop in support, or an external narrative gaining traction – so that swift corrective action can be taken. NS has endured for over half a century; with wise stewardship, it will continue to do so for future generations.

In closing, this report emphasizes that **supporting our national servicemen is not just a token of gratitude – it is an investment in the security and social stability of Singapore.** Fairness and equity in NS are not secondary to defence; they are integral to it, because a nation defends itself best when its people collectively believe in what they are defending. Every policy tweak or benefit or inclusive gesture is a signal to our servicemen and the world that Singapore values the institution of NS and the people in it. By remaining neutral in analysis but biased towards strengthening institutional legitimacy, we have provided recommendations that policymakers can consider with confidence that they serve the national interest.

National Service has often been described as the “rite of passage” for Singaporean men. If the recommendations here are pursued, we envisage an NS that could become a rite of passage for an **even broader segment of society**, directly or indirectly – one that everyone has a stake in, and whose fairness is beyond reproach. Such an NS will not only defend Singapore’s borders, but also its social fabric and the legitimacy of its institutions. In an age of uncertainty, fortifying NS in this manner is our collective insurance that the SAF and Home Team remain strong, our society remains united, and our young people continue to emerge from NS ready to contribute with pride in both military and civilian life.

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